

Exercise 1:

“What are your main reasons for using a homeless shelter?”

“Which of the following best describes your main reason for using a homeless shelter?”

- A. Housing loss
- B. Family conflict
- C. Extreme weather
- D. Other (please specify)

Advantages of open questions:

Open questions allow respondents to answer in their own words, which can provide richer, more detailed information. They are useful when the range of possible responses is unknown or when exploring new topics, as they may reveal unexpected insights.

Advantages of closed questions:

Closed questions are easier and faster for respondents to answer, and they simplify data collection and analysis. They produce standardized responses, which makes comparison across individuals and groups more straightforward.

Exercise 2:

1. What is the concept of interest?

The concept of interest is respondents’ opinions about whether city management has contributed to changes in homelessness in Chicago.

2. Can you identify an issue with this question according to the guidelines of the textbook?

Yes. The question is leading and contains loaded language. The phrase “*irresponsible management*” assumes a negative evaluation of the city’s actions, and “*made homelessness worse*” presupposes that conditions have deteriorated. This wording may bias respondents toward agreement and does not allow for neutral or alternative viewpoints.

3. How can you phrase the question to improve it?

A more neutral version would be:

“Do you think the city’s management has affected the level of homelessness in Chicago? If so, do you think it has increased, decreased, or had no effect?”

Exercise 3:

1. What is the concept of interest?

The concept of interest is students’ evaluations of their professor’s teaching effectiveness and grading fairness.

2. Can you identify an issue with this question according to the guidelines of the textbook?

Yes. This is a double-barreled question. It asks about two separate concepts, 1) clarity of explanation and 2) fairness of grading, but only allows for one combined response. A student may have different opinions about each aspect, so the question can produce ambiguous or misleading answers.

3. How can you phrase the question to improve it?

The question should be split into two separate items:

- “Do you think your professor explains the material clearly?”
- “Do you think your professor grades assignments fairly?”

Exercise 4:

1. What is the concept of interest?

The concept of interest is an individual’s annual consumption of potatoes (dietary intake of a specific food over the past year).

2. Can you identify an issue with this question according to the guidelines of the textbook?

Yes. The question is problematic because it requires respondents to recall highly specific and long-term dietary information over an entire year, which is unlikely to be accurately remembered. This introduces recall bias and increases measurement error. The question is also vague because it does not specify the

unit of measurement. Do fries count as potatoes? What is the serving size of one potato?

3. How can you phrase the question to improve it?

A clearer and more reliable version would be:

“In the past week, how many servings of potatoes did you eat?”

or

“On average, how often do you eat potatoes in a typical week?”

Exercise 5:

1. What is the concept of interest?

The concept of interest is the prevalence of marijuana use within an individual’s close social network.

2. Can you identify an issue with this question according to the guidelines of the textbook?

Yes. There are a few issues:

- **Vague definition of “closest friends”:** Respondents may interpret this differently (e.g., 3 friends vs 10 friends, or different levels of closeness).
- **Unclear measurement of “use marijuana products”:** It does not specify frequency (occasional vs regular use).
- **Social desirability of responses to questions:** Respondents may not answer this question truthfully. It may not be socially desirable to have friends who use marijuana products. If this question is asked in an area where marijuana is illegal, it will be even more difficult to obtain truthful responses from this question.

3. How can you phrase the question to improve it?

A clearer version would be:

“Thinking about up to five of your closest friends, how many do you believe have used marijuana in the past 12 months?”

Although this still does not address the challenges of collecting accurate responses for stigmatized topics, we will discuss survey design techniques for handling these issues later in the course.